

TWO APPROACHES TO STRUCTURING A COLLEGE ESSAY

TWO APPROACHES TO STRUCTURE

I think there are two basic structural approaches every student can use to write their college essays: Montage Structure and Narrative Structure. We'll explore them in detail in a bit, but to figure out which approach you might want to take...

First, ask yourself two questions:

1. Have you faced significant challenges?
2. Do you want to write about them?

To clarify: *You can write a great essay whether you've been through challenges or not.*

The question is: How?

The answer: Find the right structure.

If you answered yes to both, Narrative Structure may work well for you.

If no to either, Montage Structure offers a great approach.

You can think of Narrative Structure as classic Hollywood movie structure, focusing on a challenge that fundamentally changed your life.

Montage presents a series of experiences that are thematically linked, allowing you to present multiple sides of yourself that wouldn't all fit into a single narrative arc.

I'd like to stress that neither structure is inherently better than the other. I've seen incredible essays using both structures. I say this because I don't want you to feel like you need to write about challenges to write an outstanding college essay. You don't.

And please note that "significance" is obviously on a spectrum. We'll talk about this in greater detail soon, but keep in mind that the more significant the challenge, the easier it will be to write about it well.

With that in mind, what follows are some strategies that have helped some of my students craft compelling essays.

NARRATIVE STRUCTURE & SAMPLE ESSAY

Here's the structure that most American films use. It's a structure as old as storytelling itself, and storytellers have been using it for thousands of years. I'll refer to it as **narrative structure**. You can think of this approach to writing an essay as breaking down into three basic sections:

Challenges + Effects
What I Did About Them
What I Learned

While those may be fairly clear just based on their names, here's a brief breakdown, followed by a sample essay to illustrate:

1. **Challenges + Effects**

This part gets into specific detail regarding a specific challenge the student has faced, and the various effects of that challenge. Tough stuff you've been through. Big experiences. Their subsequent impacts. Various obstacles you've had to overcome.

2. **What I Did About Them**

Actions you took to overcome those challenges and their effects, often to meet specific needs. These actions help to illustrate your values and growth.

3. **What I Learned**

Lessons and insights you've gained through these experiences. Reflection on how your experiences have shaped you and why that matters.

Here's a sample essay that follows this format:

WHAT HAD TO BE DONE

At six years old, I stood locked away in the restroom. I held tightly to a tube of toothpaste because I'd been sent to brush my teeth to distract me from the commotion. Regardless, I knew what was happening: my dad was being put under arrest for domestic abuse. He'd hurt my mom physically and mentally,

and my brother Jose and I had shared the mental strain. It's what had to be done.

Living without a father meant money was tight, mom worked two jobs, and my brother and I took care of each other when she worked. For a brief period of time the quality of our lives slowly started to improve as our soon-to-be step-dad became an integral part of our family. He paid attention to the needs of my mom, my brother, and me. But our prosperity was short-lived as my step-dad's chronic alcoholism became more and more recurrent. When I was eight, my younger brother Fernando's birth complicated things even further. As my step-dad slipped away, my mom continued working, and Fernando's care was left to Jose and me. I cooked, Jose cleaned, I dressed Fernando, Jose put him to bed. We did what we had to do.

As undocumented immigrants and with little to no family around us, we had to rely on each other. Fearing that any disclosure of our status would risk deportation, we kept to ourselves when dealing with any financial and medical issues. I avoided going on certain school trips, and at times I was discouraged to even meet new people. I felt isolated and at times disillusioned; my grades started to slip.

Over time, however, I grew determined to improve the quality of life for my family and myself.

Without a father figure to teach me the things a father could, I became my own teacher. I learned how to fix a bike, how to swim, and even how to talk to girls. I became resourceful, fixing shoes with strips of duct tape, and I even found a job to help pay bills. I became as independent as I could to lessen the time and money mom had to spend raising me.

I also worked to apply myself constructively in other ways. I worked hard and took my grades from Bs and Cs to consecutive straight A's. I shattered my school's 100M breaststroke record, and learned how to play the clarinet, saxophone, and the oboe. Plus, I not only became the first student in my school to pass the AP Physics 1 exam, I'm currently pioneering my school's first AP Physics 2 course ever.

These changes inspired me to help others. I became president of the California Scholarship Federation, providing students with information to prepare them for college, while creating opportunities for my peers to play a bigger part in our community. I began tutoring kids, teens, and adults on a variety of subjects ranging from basic English to home improvement and even

Calculus. As the captain of the water polo and swim team I've led practices crafted to individually push my comrades to their limits, and I've counseled friends through circumstances similar to mine. I've done tons, and I can finally say I'm proud of that.

But I'm excited to say that there's so much I have yet to do. I haven't danced the tango, solved a Rubix Cube, explored how perpetual motion might fuel space exploration, or seen the World Trade Center. And I have yet to see the person that Fernando will become.

I'll do as much as I can from now on. Not because I have to. Because I choose to.

MONTAGE STRUCTURE & SAMPLE ESSAY

WHAT IS A MONTAGE?

Montage is something you've likely all encountered before, but some may not be familiar with the word itself. It's a technique that involves using separate elements (pictures, words, music, etc.) to create a new whole. In filmmaking, the montage effect is used to condense space and time so that information can be delivered in a more efficient way.

Take the classic "falling in love" montage, commonly used in romantic comedies. We don't see every single interaction. Instead, we see: one surprises the other at work, probably with flowers; they walk through the park; they dance in the rain; they pass an engagement ring store. You get the idea.

A few images work together to tell a larger story. And you can use this technique for your essay to tell a larger story about you.

FIND A THEMATIC THREAD

If you're going to build a montage, you need to find a way to make the different experiences you'll use feel connected. Think of it this way: if I just had a paragraph on growing up in Latin America, speaking of which religion, speaking of which literature is important to me, speaking of which... you're going to feel understandably confused. So I need to have something that threads the pieces together.

The sample essay below (“Laptop Stickers”) was written by a student who collected stickers on her laptop. Each sticker connected to different values and experiences. Stickers are her thematic thread.

There are virtually infinite things that could work as a thematic thread to tie your montage together. A place? An art form? A hobby? We’ll explore an exercise in a bit that can help you do so. But for now, here’s that “Laptop Stickers” essay, so you can more clearly see what I mean by a montage and thread.

MY LAPTOP STICKERS

My laptop is like a passport. It is plastered with stickers all over the outside, inside, and bottom. Each sticker is a stamp, representing a place I’ve been, a passion I’ve pursued, or community I’ve belonged to. These stickers make for an untraditional first impression at a meeting or presentation, but it’s one I’m proud of. Let me take you on a quick tour:

*“**We <3 Design**,” bottom left corner. Art has been a constant for me for as long as I can remember. Today my primary engagement with art is through design. I’ve spent entire weekends designing websites and social media graphics for my companies. Design means more to me than just branding and marketing; it gives me the opportunity to experiment with texture, perspective, and contrast, helping me refine my professional style.*

*“**Common Threads**,” bottom right corner. A rectangular black and red sticker displaying the theme of the 2017 TEDxYouth@Austin event. For years I’ve been interested in the street artists and musicians in downtown Austin who are so unapologetically themselves. As a result, I’ve become more open-minded and appreciative of unconventional lifestyles. TED gives me the opportunity to help other youth understand new perspectives, by exposing them to the diversity of Austin where culture is created, not just consumed.*

***Poop emoji**, middle right. My 13-year-old brother often sends his messages with the poop emoji ‘echo effect,’ so whenever I open a new message from him, hundreds of poops elegantly cascade across my screen. He brings out my goofy side, but also helps me think rationally when I am overwhelmed. We don’t have the typical “I hate you, don’t talk to me” siblinghood (although occasionally it would be nice to get away from him); we’re each other’s best friends. Or at least he’s mine.*

*“**Lol ur not Harry Styles**,” upper left corner. Bought in seventh grade and*

transferred from my old laptop, this sticker is torn but persevering with layers of tape. Despite conveying my fangirl-y infatuation with Harry Styles' boyband, One Direction, for me Styles embodies an artist-activist who uses his privilege for the betterment of society. As a \$42K donor to the Time's Up Legal Defense Fund, a hair donor to the Little Princess Trust, and promoter of LGBTQ+ equality, he has motivated me to be a more public activist instead of internalizing my beliefs.

*“**Catapult**,” middle right. This is the logo of a startup incubator where I launched my first company, Threading Twine. I learned that business can provide others access to fundamental human needs, such as economic empowerment of minorities and education. In my career, I hope to be a corporate advocate for the empowerment of women, creating large-scale impact and deconstructing institutional boundaries that obstruct women from working in high-level positions. Working as a women's rights activist will allow me to engage in creating lasting movements for equality, rather than contributing to a cycle that elevates the stances of wealthy individuals.*

*“**Thank God it's Monday**,” sneakily nestled in the upper right corner. Although I attempt to love all my stickers equally (haha), this is one of my favorites. I always want my association with work to be positive.*

*And there are many others, including the horizontal, yellow stripes of the **Human Rights Campaign**; “**The Team**,” a sticker from the Model G20 Economics Summit where I collaborated with youth from around the globe; and stickers from “**Kode with Klossy**,” a community of girls working to promote women's involvement in underrepresented fields.*

When my computer dies (hopefully not for another few years), it will be like my passport expiring. It'll be difficult leaving these moments and memories behind, but I probably won't want these stickers in my 20s anyways (except Harry Styles, that's never leaving). My next set of stickers will reveal my next set of aspirations. They hold the key to future paths I will navigate, knowledge I will gain, and connections I will make.

HOW TO BRAINSTORM A MONTAGE ESSAY

THE MONTAGE ESSAY

The “Laptop Stickers” essay you read employs Montage Structure. If you answered “no” to either feeling like you have faced challenges or wanting to write about them, this structure will likely work well for you.

And by the way, isn't it nice to know that you don't have to have experienced extraordinary challenges to write a great college essay? (See essay below.)

To learn how to develop the content for a montage, we'll work through a simple but effective exercise.

STEP 1: PICK FIVE LINKED THINGS IN YOUR LIFE.

By "linked," I mean five things that have a thematic connection—maybe five pairs of shoes that connect to different experiences that demonstrate your values and aspects of who you are. Or five mountain peaks. Five families you've learned from. Five photographs you took. Five decisions you've made. Five things you've collected. Five entries in your [Happiness Spreadsheet](#). You can start by exploring your Essence Objects exercise.

STEP 2: OUTLINE HOW EACH OF THE FIVE COULD CONNECT TO DIFFERENT EXPERIENCES THAT SHOW DIFFERENT VALUES.

For example, maybe there are five different places or experiences that feel like "Home" to you. Connect each home to different values from your [Values Exercise](#). Maybe one home links to experiences that connect to culture and meticulousness, another connects to science and curiosity, another connects to personal growth...

And to clarify, you may not end up with all five things in your final draft. Or conversely, maybe you end up with more than five (like eight [laptop stickers](#)). But for now, aim for five, and do some exploring.

(Note: You can also use the [5 Things Exercise](#) to brainstorm content if you're finding yourself (or your students) needing more structure.)

Here are some...

TIPS FOR FINDING A GOOD THEMATIC THREAD

1. Visual threads are easier to write. Storytelling is a visual medium. Use a lens that will help conjure images in the reader's mind. I've had too many students try to write "soundtrack" or "mix-tape" essays in which their favorite songs provide the soundtrack for their lives. The problem with writing this type of essay, however, is that the reader can't hear the music (and often doesn't know or have the same emotional connection

to the songs referenced). So you can use more abstract things (like Waves, or Home), but those will often take more time to write well.

2. Write what you know. Know how to cook? Use food. Play chess? Use that! Use your Essence Objects list as a starting point for ideas.
3. Look for thematic threads that are “elastic”—that allow you to connect a bunch of sides of yourself. Use a metaphor, in other words, that will allow you to discuss several different aspects of who you are.